Covered, Arranged or Not Sure Yet: A One-Page Sheet of the Words for Sorting Dad's Care

Seventeen words in one plain line each, and what to write down beside each.

Sorting out Dad's care takes a handful of words used carefully. This sheet gives each one a plain line, and says what to write down when you use it.

The first group and the last are the Family Care Roadmap's own working words. Where a word comes from a public source, the source is marked. None of it is for judging Dad's care or the people who give it.

Three words for sorting a line

Covered

A need with a name beside it, where you or someone you can name has seen the help happen.

WRITE DOWN Who covers it, who saw it, and when.

Arranged

Help that is on the plan or the schedule and that nobody in the family has seen happen yet. It may be going exactly as written.

WRITE DOWN "Scheduled, not seen," and who could tell you.

Not sure yet

Something you haven't confirmed either way. It is a question, not a failure.

WRITE DOWN The question as you'd ask it on the phone, and the person or office you'd ask.

Needs and help

Documented need

Something Dad needs help with that is written down somewhere: in the care plan, in instructions you were given, or in your own dated notes.

WRITE DOWN The need in a few words, and where it's written.

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks of everyday life: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, transferring to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

WRITE DOWN For each one on Dad's plan, who helps and how you know.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Everyday tasks: housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing and cleaning up after meals, shopping, using the telephone, caring for pets, and responding to emergency alerts. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now, paid or not.

Care plan

The CDC's name for a form that summarizes a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether Dad has one, who wrote it, the date on it, and where your copy is.

Plan of care

In Medicare home health, the list of what services are needed, which health care professionals should give them, and when and how often. Medicare says it is reviewed as often as necessary, but at least once every 60 days. [3]

WRITE DOWN Whether a home health agency is involved, and the date on the plan you hold.

Support currently provided

The help that reaches Dad in an ordinary week, from anyone. The Administration for Community Living says about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers, so family counts. [4]

WRITE DOWN Each person who helps, what they do, and which days.

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday caregiving responsibilities, as the National Institute on Aging describes the role. [5]

WRITE DOWN Who that is right now, and what that person covers that isn't on any schedule.

Meaningful activities

Activities that create a sense of purpose in daily life, such as hobbies, volunteer activities, or time with family and friends. [6]

WRITE DOWN What Dad enjoys and whether it still happens. What he wants more of is his choice.

The lines on a list of gaps

Gap

A need with no one named beside it, or a difference between what the plan says and what you've seen. It is a line on a list, not a verdict.

WRITE DOWN The need, what the plan says and what you saw, in neutral words.

Source and date

Where a piece of information came from, and when. Three people repeating what one person said is still one source.

WRITE DOWN "Dad said," "the schedule says" or "I saw," each with a date.

Impact, in their words

What a gap is like for Dad or for the family, as they describe it.

WRITE DOWN Their words, with who said them. Not your estimate of how serious it is.

Professional review

The label for a question that isn't the family's to answer: anything about Dad's health, his medications, or what a gap means for him.

WRITE DOWN The question, marked for his doctor, nurse or pharmacist, or for your care consultant. Leave the answer blank.

Owner

The one person who has agreed to follow up on an open line. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests a written summary of what each person has agreed to. [7]

WRITE DOWN One name per open line, and what that person will find out.

Status

Where a line stands today: open, asked or answered.

WRITE DOWN One of those three words, and the date it last changed.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words and says what to note beside them. It doesn't say whether Dad's help is enough, what a gap means for him, or what should change. Those questions go to the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You have the words, and you know what to write beside each one. The care interview puts them to work on the whole picture: it goes through Dad's daily life one area at a time, asks who covers each part, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Medicare & Home Health Care (CMS Product No. 10969)
4. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
5. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
6. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

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